

1. For any accurate sense experience, I can imagine a situation which is indistinguishable from that sense experience but in which my environment is not as the experience says it is.
2. There are situations which I cannot rule out which would make beliefs formed on the basis of sense experience false.
(1)
3. If you cannot rule out a situation which would make P false, you should not believe P. (Doubt $\rightarrow$ No Belief)
4. You should not form beliefs on the basis of sense experience. (2,3)
5. Sense experience is your only source of information about the world outside of you.

C. You should not form any beliefs about the world outside of you. (4,5)

AN ARGUMENT FOR SKEPTICISM ABOUT THE EXTERNAL WORLD

The conclusion of this argument is quite surprising. Can it really be true that we should withhold forming any beliefs about the world around us?

It is tempting to think that we should be able to respond to these arguments by finding some way to show that certain experiences are not illusions.

For example, one might argue that, since our sense experiences are usually accurate, it is reasonable to form beliefs about the external world on their basis.

But how do we know that our sense experiences are usually accurate?
Presumably on the basis of past sense experiences. And those experiences can be doubted just as much as our present experiences. The attempt to respond to defend the reliability of our current sense experiences on the basis of the reliability of past sense experiences seems to go in a circle.

If you think about it, it looks like any attempt to reply to our argument for skepticism is going to involve this kind of circular reasoning.

This is a very unsettling argument. And notice that it is not limited to our beliefs about tables and chairs; our beliefs about other people are also based on sense experience. So it looks like you have no reason to believe that anyone besides you exists.

We might try to construct an argument based on science. For example, science tells us that our visual experiences are caused by light reflecting off of the surface of physical objects and interacting with our eye, causing effects in our visual cortex. Given this, don't the existence of our sense experiences show that there must be physical objects around us to reflect light?

But there's an immediate problem here. The scientific theories on which this reply relies are themselves based on sense experience. So if we rely on those theories, we are tacitly relying on the very thing — the reliability of our sense experiences — which we were trying to establish.



1. For any accurate sense experience, I can imagine a situation which is indistinguishable from that sense experience but in which my environment is not as the experience says it is.
2. There are situations which I cannot rule out which would make beliefs formed on the basis of sense experience false.
(1)
3. If you cannot rule out a situation which would make P false, you should not believe P. (Doubt $\rightarrow$ No Belief)
4. You should not form beliefs on the basis of sense experience. (2,3)
5. Sense experience is your only source of information about the world outside of you.

C. You should not form any beliefs about the world outside of you. (4,5)



AN ARGUMENT FOR SKEPTICISM ABOUT THE EXTERNAL WORLD

we should withhold forming any beliefs about the world around us?

The conclusion of this argument is quite surprising. Can it really be true that

It is tempting to think that we should be able to respond to these arguments by

finding a way to show that certain experiences are not illusions.

accurate, it is reasonable to form beliefs about the external world on their basis.

For example, one might argue that, since our senses are usually

defend the reliability of our current sense experiences on the basis of the

doubted just as much as our present experience. The attempt to respond to

Presumably on the basis of past sensory experiences. And those experiences can be

But how do we know that our sense experiences are usually accurate?

reliability of past sense experiences to go in a circle.

Let's try a second reply. Science tells us that our visual experiences are caused

senses experiences that have to be physical objects and to reflect



by light reflecting off the surface of physical objects and interacting with our

Right?

eye, causing effects in our visual cortex. Given this, don't the existence of our

But this fact exactly the same problem. The scientific theories which this

experiences — which were trying to establish.

reply relies are themselves based on sensory experience. So if we rely on those

theories, we are tacitly relying on the very thing—the reliability of our sense

skepticism is going to involve this kind of circular reasoning.

if you think about it, it's like any attempt to reply to an argument for

This is a very unsettling argument. And notice that it is not limited to our

sense experience. So it makes like you have reason to believe that any one

besides you exists.

beliefs about tables and chairs; our beliefs about other people are also based on

tell us that our visual experiences are caused by light reflecting off the

We might try to construct an argument based on science. For example,

they must be physical objects and must reflect light?

visual cortex. Given this, don't the existence of our sense experiences show that

surface of physical objects and interacting with our eye, causing effects in our

But there's an immediate problem here. The scientific theories on which this

theories, we are tacitly relying on the very thing—the reliability of our sense

reply relies are themselves based on sensory experience. So if we rely on those

experiences — which were trying to establish.

skepticism is going to involve this kind of circular reasoning.

if you think about it, it's like any attempt to reply to an argument for